

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



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> **"IF THE PM IS NOT A FRIEND (OF ADANI), THEN HE SHOULD HAVE AGREED TO AN INQUIRY. THERE WAS NO PROBE INTO SHELL FIRMS IN THE DEFENCE CONTRACTS..."**
>
> **RAHUL GANDHI**
> *Congress leader, MP*

ning several government tenders and infrastructure projects in ports, airports, roads, rail, fossil fuels and green energy across the country. In 2018, a controversial decision by the Modi government—not making prior experience a requisite and ignoring red flags by the finance ministry and NITI Aayog—allowed Adani to bid and win tenders for six airports. Adani had no prior experience operating airports, but the decision turned his group into one of the country's biggest private airport operators overnight.

The documents available suggest that the PPP division of NITI Aayog had reservations that the bidder lacked technical capacity and could jeopardise the project. However, an empowered group of secretaries had already decided to not make prior experience a prerequisite. "There was a strong argument that it will enlarge the competition," says a bureaucrat privy to the discussions. He added that other than Adani, GMR Group, Zurich Airport, Cochin International Airport and Changi Airport (Singapore) had participated in the bids. There were arguments from the department of economic